news of Akbar's approach. From Kabul, in July, he sent replies to Akbar's stern messages, filled with apologies. Akbar was unconvinced. Hakim should have submitted in person, or sent one of his sons, or Khwaja Hasan Naqshbandi – now Hakim's brother-in-law – to submit on his behalf. In fact, anticipating such half-hearted surrender, Akbar had already sent out an army under Man Singh and the eleven-year-old Prince Murad with orders to march – but slowly – upon Kabul. Akbar himself had waited a long while to cross the Indus, 'lest by the crossing of the army things would go beyond the prospect of peace' – but had taken the plunge ten days before Hakim's unconvincing apologies arrived. Now, he summoned a council of twenty amirs, telling them to draft a reply and bring it to him the next day.[31]

Just as Akbar's own stand across the Indus had changed, so had the composition of his nobility. Many of his amirs were Indian now, and had already travelled too far into unknown land. And none of them, writes Abul Fazl, wanted to go to Kabul – some from 'dread of a cold country', others from 'love for India'; some even 'influenced by good will towards [Hakim]'. With the exception of Abul Fazl's stubborn voice – 'I had not white hair and long beard,' he declares – the amirs agreed that Akbar should forgive Hakim, so that they might turn back around and quickly go home.

Abul Fazl's little sermon on how it was 'proper to finish the work which is nearly completed' did not go down well with the others. '[T]hey were angry,' he writes, 'and consulted together with evil intentions.' One of them advised Abul Fazl to make himself more amenable, 'especially with those who are powerful in the state' – suggesting, clearly, that Akbar's favour was not enough to ensure a successful career; there were other powerful men who could make life difficult for an intransigent colleague. Abul Fazl agreed to a compromise: he would not offer his opinion in court unless he was asked for it.

The next day, as it happens, Abul Fazl was unwell; he does not say so, but he might have developed one of those nervous aches that afflict a person anticipating a tense day at work. The amirs went to court free of worry and declared themselves unanimously in favour of forgiving Mirza Hakim and forgetting about marching into Kabul. When Akbar asked about the absent Abul Fazl's opinion, one of them, most 'shameless', replied, 'He too agrees with this opinion.'